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This sudden turn of events startled both Liang Shi and Gu Zhaoyuan at the same time.

"Father." Gu Zhaoyuan stepped forward and held him down. "Calm down a little."

But Dean Gu kept shouting: "Lunatic! Lunatic! Crazy woman!"

Liang Shi stood up and took half a step back, momentarily unsure whether she should continue asking questions.

After a moment of hesitation, she continued to ask: "Dean, you know Yang Jiani, don't you? Did she do something to Gu Xingyue?"

Upon hearing the name Gu Xingyue, Gu Zhaoyuan was stunned, and his grip loosened.

Dean Gu suddenly broke free and ran madly toward Liang Shi, directly grabbing her by the collar. "You lunatic!"

Liang Shi felt somewhat uncomfortable from being choked, her brows furrowed tightly, but she didn't forcefully break free, afraid of hurting Dean Gu.

Dean Gu's mouth kept repeating the same few phrases.

Lunatic, crazy woman, get out.

Gu Zhaoyuan was also afraid that continuing to talk would further agitate his father. After restraining his father, he asked Liang Shi to step outside first.

The deep corridor was empty and silent, with no one passing through.

The nursing home was quiet at night; only a few birds occasionally flew overhead in circles, and before long, even the birds disappeared.

More than ten minutes later, Gu Zhaoyuan finally emerged from the room drenched in sweat. He first said to Liang Shi in a low voice: "I'm sorry, my father didn't hurt you, did he?"

"No," Liang Shi replied.

Gu Zhaoyuan had given Dean Gu a sedative, and Dean Gu had fallen into a deep sleep.

Liang Shi had just learned that Dean Gu would go mad from time to time, but there were occasionally moments during each day when he was lucid—it all depended on luck.

Actually, Liang Shi was quite lucky today. When she arrived, Dean Gu happened to be lucid and was even reading a book.

It was only because Liang Shi mentioned Yang Jiani that he became agitated and went mad again.

After apologizing to her, Gu Zhaoyuan asked who Yang Jiani was and why she had mentioned his younger sister.

Liang Shi only said vaguely: "Perhaps your sister hasn't passed away, but I can't tell you anything more than that."

She only promised Gu Zhaoyuan that if she found Gu Xingyue one day, and if Gu Xingyue was willing, she would bring Gu Xingyue to meet him.

The amount of information was overwhelming, leaving Gu Zhaoyuan at a loss for words.

He asked three times in a row: "My sister is still alive?"

Liang Shi nodded. "She should still be alive."

She didn't give a completely certain answer.

But for Gu Zhaoyuan, this was already tremendously good news. However, after the initial excitement passed, Gu Zhaoyuan calmed down and thought: "So my father decided to rebuild the orphanage because of what happened to my sister?"

"That possibility can't be ruled out," Liang Shi said. "But for the specifics, you'd have to ask your father."

Gu Zhaoyuan smiled bitterly. "You've also seen his current condition. I just hope he can spend his remaining years in peace."

Liang Shi nodded. "Then I've disturbed you this time. I'm sorry."

"It's fine. I'm truly very grateful for the information you've provided." Gu Zhaoyuan said sincerely: "Miss Liang, you must find my sister. Even if we don't meet, just let me know that she's still alive and well in this world."

Liang Shi nodded. "I'll do my best."

Afterward, the two of them discussed some matters about establishing an orphanage. In this regard, Gu Zhaoyuan was an expert, so Liang Shi simply agreed with what he said.

Under the bright moon and sparse stars¹, Liang Shi drove away from the nursing home.

After Gu Zhaoyuan watched her car leave, he hurried back to his father's room.

He saw his father lying on the bed, hands tightly gripping the bedsheets, his face aged.

Even in his sleep, he was softly murmuring: "Xingyue."

Gu Zhaoyuan stood at the doorway, sighing helplessly.

After a while, he bent down to pick up the torn books scattered on the floor.

1. 夜朗星稀 (yè lǎng xīng xī) - A classical Chinese expression describing a night scene where the moon is bright and the stars are few. It's a poetic way to describe a clear, moonlit night. ↩

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After work, Xu Qingzhu went straight back to the Xu family home.

Her car followed behind Xu Guangyao's car. When they arrived, she greeted Xu Guangyao.

But Xu Guangyao furrowed his brows slightly: "Why did you come back?"

"What kind of question is that?" Xu Qingzhu walked alongside him. "Can't I come back to my own home?"

Xu Guangyao paused before saying: "If you want to talk about company matters, let's discuss it at the office tomorrow."

"It's not about the company." Xu Qingzhu said: "I just came home to have a meal with you."

Her eyes tilted upward, her tone carrying a hint of displeasure. "Could it be that you don't welcome me?"

Xu Guangyao entered the door. "How could that be?"

Most of the servants in the house had been let go earlier, and only three remained now.

As soon as Xu Qingzhu entered, she asked: "Where's my mom?"

"Madam is in the Buddhist prayer room," a servant answered.

Xu Qingzhu glanced toward the second floor, then changed her shoes and entered the house. The aroma of food was already wafting through the home.

After returning home, Xu Guangyao took off his suit jacket and loosened his tie. Seeing her preoccupied expression, he asked hesitantly: "What do you need to see your mom about?"

Xu Qingzhu said: "Just to chat with my mom."

"It's not about divorcing Liang Shi, is it?" Xu Guangyao suddenly asked.

Xu Qingzhu paused, then smiled and replied using his earlier tone: "How could that be?"

"You'll be promoted to General Manager next week." Xu Guangyao said in a deep voice: "Since you want to do it, I'll hand over the authority to you. I'm getting old and can't keep going. If Liang Shi has no objections, then go ahead—but you need to take care of your health."

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together. "Didn't you say we shouldn't discuss business matters at home?"

"I just happened to be free, so I'm mentioning it." Xu Guangyao said: "You're not young anymore, and you know your own health condition. Don't always act recklessly, wanting to do everything, only to ruin your health in the end."

Xu Qingzhu knew these words were for her own good and nodded: "I understand. I'll be more careful in the future."

"You and Liang Shi haven't had any problems, have you?" Xu Guangyao still asked worriedly. "You didn't join Minghui because you want a divorce, did you?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu answered patiently: "There are no problems."

She suddenly felt grateful that her decision back then was the right one.

If she had divorced Liang Shi, coming home would inevitably mean being interrogated about everything, and it would bring a heavy, oppressive atmosphere to this family.

"Ah." Xu Guangyao sighed. "Let's wait until next year. Once you've gotten a handle on the company's operations, I plan to retire. Your mother has been cooped up at home all these years. I want to take her traveling to relax."

"So suddenly?" Xu Qingzhu was surprised. "Didn't you still want to..."

Realizing that what she was about to say might be hurtful, she stopped herself in time.

Before this, Xu Guangyao had been arguing with her in the office, thinking she was still too young, displaying an attitude of being unwilling to hand over power.

At the time, she couldn't figure out whether he was keeping her from joining the company because he was worried about her health, or whether Xu Guangyao simply craved power.

Now it seemed like the former was more likely.

"What did I want?" Xu Guangyao looked at her. "Did you think I was planning to leave the company to Qingya?"

"No..." Xu Qingzhu denied.

She had indeed never thought about that, because for her, joining the company was all about preserving the Sheng family's business.

It was simply that she didn't want Minghui to decline.

"Minghui is yours." Xu Guangyao said: "This has never changed over the years. It's just that your health has been poor, and I once wanted to turn the situation around before handing Minghui over to you. But now it seems you're more capable than I am."

Xu Guangyao had Xu Qingzhu follow him to the study, where he took out their grandfather's testament¹. In the column for Minghui's equity distribution, it clearly stated: Xu Qingzhu 36%, Xu Qingya 10%, Sheng Linlang 3%, Xu Guangyao 2%.

The combined shares of the other three people in this family didn't even equal hers alone. Moreover, it clearly stated that this was to be executed after Xu Qingzhu's graduation, with Xu Guangyao only acting as a custodian.

Minghui had always belonged to Xu Qingzhu from the very beginning.

If she hadn't known about her own origins before, seeing this testament suddenly would have seemed unreasonable. But now that she knew, everything made perfect sense.

Xu Guangyao didn't steer the conversation toward her origins either. He simply said: "Your grandparents always doted on you the most. When they passed away, Qingya had just been born and didn't have much of a bond with them, so they left the most to you. But all these years... I really couldn't feel at ease handing Minghui over to you."

"Don't laugh at me for saying this, but when I first took over Minghui, I got sick several times." Xu Guangyao said: "All-night meetings, overnight business trips, constantly staying up late—it was very, very difficult."

Xu Qingzhu finished reading through the testament before asking: "So why have you changed your mind now?"

Xu Guangyao stared at her. "Isn't this what you wanted?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Before graduation, she had also subtly expressed her desire to join the company. But at that time, in the lingering cold of early spring², she went out for an internship for just one week and caught a severe cold—the kind where she couldn't even get out of bed. Afterward, Xu Guangyao looked at her and said: "Why bother working? Just rest and recuperate at home."

So her internship experience was actually a fake one that Xu Guangyao had arranged from his own company.

She had barely worked a few days at all.

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1. 醫囑 (yī zhǔ) - While this term literally means "medical instructions" or "doctor's orders," in this context it refers to a will or testament left by the grandfather. The author may have used this term loosely or it could be a typo for 遺囑 (yí zhǔ), which means "will" or "testament." ↵
 2. 春寒料峭 (chūn hán liào qiào) - A Chinese idiom describing the biting cold that lingers in early spring, when winter's chill hasn't fully retreated despite the arrival of spring. ↵

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Xu Guangyao laughed, the wrinkles at the corners of his eyes particularly prominent. "You weren't this well-behaved when you were calling me old-fashioned in the office."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She retorted, "I didn't call you old-fashioned. I was just discussing the matter at hand."

"I know." Xu Guangyao ran his hand through his hair, revealing a patch of white. He said in a deep voice: "You have talent in this area. Go ahead and do it. It's just that I didn't do well all these years and almost ran Minghui into the ground."

"Did you do your best?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Xu Guangyao was stunned for a moment, then smiled bitterly. "I did my best, but my abilities were limited."

Xu Qingzhu said: "Then that's enough. If you did your best, you have nothing to feel guilty about."

Xu Guangyao stood in the study, silent for a long time.

Xu Qingzhu gazed at his back and noticed that he had aged considerably. He was no longer the tall figure from her memories.

"After I joined the company, you've been under a lot of pressure, haven't you?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Xu Guangyao turned around and smiled. "I was afraid you'd collapse from illness."

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "Don't worry. I'll take good care of myself."

After finishing her conversation with Xu Guangyao in the study, Xu Qingzhu couldn't shake the feeling that something was off.

But she couldn't put her finger on it, though she felt a vague unease in her heart.

After they came out of the study, Sheng Linlang still hadn't emerged from the Buddhist prayer room.

Xu Qingzhu said: "I'll go upstairs to call her."

Over the years, Sheng Linlang hadn't been very social. She only appeared in public view when she occasionally needed to attend banquets. She didn't like shopping either, always staying home alone copying Buddhist scriptures and chanting sutras.

To make it more convenient for her, Xu Guangyao had converted one of the bedrooms in the house into a Buddhist prayer room. Inside was enshrined a Buddha statue that had been invited from a particularly efficacious temple in China¹.

The Buddha statue wasn't large, but it was pure gold.

Although Xu Qingzhu didn't believe in gods or Buddha, she respected Sheng Linlang's religious beliefs.

Besides, this was Sheng Linlang's only hobby.

Xu Qingzhu went upstairs and knocked lightly on the door. Before long, Sheng Linlang opened the door. She was somewhat surprised to see Xu Qingzhu, but smiled and said: "Why did you suddenly come back? You didn't even call."

"I missed you, so I came back." Xu Qingzhu hugged her. "Are you done chanting? It's time to go downstairs for dinner."

Sheng Linlang put the prayer beads she had been fingering onto her fair wrist. "I was just casually chanting. It's nothing formal. I can stop anytime."

"Then let's go eat." Xu Qingzhu held her hand and led her downstairs.

Sheng Linlang's hands were very soft, but her footsteps were unsteady as they went downstairs. Xu Qingzhu glanced at her from the side and noticed that her chin looked thin and gaunt. She couldn't help but frown: "Haven't you been eating properly lately? Why are you so thin?"

Sheng Linlang was startled, then smiled: "I have been eating. It's just that the weather has gotten cold and my appetite isn't good."

"Isn't it usually hot weather that makes people lose their appetite?" Xu Qingzhu said: "It's almost winter. You need to store up some fat for the season."

"It'll get better after a while," Sheng Linlang said dismissively.

Xu Qingzhu felt doubtful in her heart but didn't say anything.

After they finished eating, she called Sheng Linlang to her room, saying she had something to ask.

Xu Qingzhu's room was the same as before she got married. It had always been cleaned by someone, and everything was placed in its original position, untouched by anyone.

Her room was decorated in sky blue tones—a very bright color scheme—completely designed according to her preferences.

Thinking back, it seemed that from childhood to adulthood, whatever she wanted, her parents never denied her.

So she had always lived a very content and happy life.

Sheng Linlang sat on the edge of the bed with her and suddenly asked: "Are you going to stay home and sleep tonight?"

"Would you like me to stay?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Sheng Linlang was taken aback, her expression immediately becoming serious. "Did you have a fight with Liang Shi? What happened?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu denied once again. "Nothing happened between me and Liang Shi. There are just some other things I want to ask you about."

Hearing that nothing was wrong between the two of them, Sheng Linlang finally relaxed.

"What is it then?" Sheng Linlang asked: "Is it related to Jiani? We really haven't been in contact for many years."

"It's not about Yang Jiani," Xu Qingzhu said.

She took a deep breath and was silent for a moment before saying: "What I want to ask about is Su Yao."

"Su Yao?" Sheng Linlang's pupils suddenly contracted. "Why... why are you asking about her?"

Xu Qingzhu didn't hide anything. She smiled bitterly: "I've already met her."

Sheng Linlang's expression became very complicated. Her eyes were also filled with too many emotions—shock, astonishment, sadness, fear... too many things that Xu Qingzhu couldn't understand.

Sheng Linlang opened her mouth several times but couldn't say anything.

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu looked at her. "Can you tell me what happened twenty-three years ago?"

Sheng Linlang closed her eyes, tears sliding down her cheeks. She shook her head and said: "How did you find out?"

As she spoke, her hands kept fingering the prayer beads, and the speed kept increasing.

Finally... the string snapped, and the prayer beads scattered all over the floor.

Xu Qingzhu squatted down to pick them up. She bent over and gathered a few, but Sheng Linlang suddenly grabbed her hand. "Don't pick them up. Let the housekeeper clean them up later."

"Are you feeling better?" Xu Qingzhu asked: "If you don't want to talk about it, I won't listen."

"Besides Su Yao, have you met anyone else?" Sheng Linlang asked.

After the initial shock, her emotions were now quite calm. She didn't desperately tell Xu Qingzhu not to meet Su Yao, nor did she storm out, nor did she forcefully insist that Xu Qingzhu not know about these things.

Sheng Linlang only sighed softly, gentle as always.

Like a pool of still water, she could easily soothe the anxiety in one's heart.

Perhaps it was related to her nature. Since childhood, Xu Qingzhu had never seen Sheng Linlang lose her temper. No matter when, she always spoke softly and smiled gently—a typical lady of a prestigious family².

Xu Qingzhu had always felt that those noble young ladies portrayed in TV dramas couldn't compare to even one-thousandth of Sheng Linlang.

Whether in terms of looks or temperament.

That's why she dared to come home and ask, and was certain that Sheng Linlang wouldn't lie to her.

"Also Su Zhe," Xu Qingzhu said gently. "He came to see me yesterday."

"What did he say?" Sheng Linlang asked. "Did he mention what happened before?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "So I wanted to hear what you have to say. What he said may not necessarily be accurate."

Sheng Linlang shook her head with a bitter smile. "It's probably accurate."

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1. 請來的佛 (qǐng lái de fó) - In Chinese Buddhist tradition, Buddha statues are not simply "bought" but "invited" (請) from temples. This reflects the belief that the statue carries spiritual significance and blessing. When a statue comes from a particularly "efficacious" (靈) temple, it's believed to carry stronger spiritual power. ⇐
 2. 大家閨秀 (dà jiā guī xiù) - A traditional Chinese term referring to a young lady from a wealthy, prestigious, or noble family who has been raised with refined manners, education, and grace. Such women were expected to be cultured, modest, elegant, and well-versed in traditional feminine arts. ⇐

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Afterward, Sheng Linlang gently told Xu Qingzhu about what happened more than twenty years ago, interspersed with her experiences with Sheng Qinglin.

Throughout Xu Qingzhu's upbringing, Sheng Linlang rarely mentioned Sheng Qinglin, as if deliberately avoiding the topic in front of her.

But occasionally she would say to Xu Qingya: "You have a very amazing uncle."

So when Xu Qingya was in kindergarten, she would brag to others about how amazing her uncle was.

Xu Qingzhu had limited experiences at school; most of the time she stayed at home, and she hadn't heard Sheng Linlang talk much about her uncle.

Thinking about it now, it was probably because Sheng Linlang didn't want her to know too much.

The Sheng siblings had contrasting personalities—one tough, one gentle.

Sheng Linlang had been gentle and quiet since childhood, with a soft temperament and easy to talk to. Sheng Qinglin, on the other hand, was stubborn with a touch of an artist's pride. He skipped grades and was soon in the same class as his older sister.

The two had a very close relationship. At school, anyone who wanted to pursue Sheng Linlang had to get past Sheng Qinglin first.

Even after all these years, when Sheng Linlang mentioned Sheng Qinglin, she said that back in their school days, he was quite the troublemaker who often gathered friends together and invited people to drink. No matter how much Sheng Linlang tried to advise him, he wouldn't listen.

But then he went to university and became devoted to academics.

Sheng Qinglin loved architectural design and had extremely high talent in this field.

Compared to him, Sheng Linlang seemed to only have beauty as her advantage.

Sheng Qinglin met Su Yao in university. The two fell in love at first sight and quickly entered a passionate relationship.

After they started dating, Sheng Qinglin often brought Su Yao to meet Sheng Linlang, so Sheng Linlang and Su Yao also knew each other and had a good relationship.

Before they even graduated, Sheng Qinglin had already brought Su Yao home several times.

When the two were about to go abroad to study, Grandmother Sheng gave Su Yao an heirloom bracelet, saying it was for her future daughter-in-law.

When Sheng Linlang saw Sheng Qinglin off at the airport, she cried so hard she could barely breathe. Sheng Qinglin said: "If you keep crying like this, I won't leave."

It was Su Yao who comforted Sheng Linlang, saying that after they left, she would take good care of Sheng Qinglin. She would also text Sheng Linlang and would definitely supervise Sheng Qinglin to study hard and achieve something.

Sheng Linlang said: "I just hope he stays safe and sound."

Su Yao said confidently: "He definitely will."

While abroad, Su Yao unexpectedly became pregnant. They originally wanted to hold the wedding while her belly wasn't showing yet, but it happened to coincide with Sheng Qinglin participating in an important engineering design project. Su Yao said it wouldn't be too late to hold the wedding after the baby was born.

During Su Yao's pregnancy, she would call Sheng Linlang every day for more than half an hour, chatting about everyday things and life back home.

But no one expected the accident to come so suddenly.

The night before Sheng Qinglin's proposal, he was still asking Sheng Linlang how exactly he should kneel on one knee to look both handsome and special.

Sheng Linlang teased him, saying he was already a father but still acting like a young kid.

Sheng Qinglin then said proudly: "My daughter is especially beautiful. I'm planning to name her Su Qingzhu, with Yaoyao's surname."

"Will Mom and Dad agree?" Sheng Linlang was somewhat worried.

The Sheng parents were rather traditional and would think it better for the child to take the Alpha's surname.

"Can't I just register my little Zhuzi's household registration¹ when we get back?" Sheng Qinglin said smugly. "When have Mom and Dad ever been able to control me?"

Sheng Linlang laughed in spite of herself. "That's true."

Sheng Qinglin also asked her if she was seeing anyone. If she was, she had to tell him immediately and bring the person for him to vet. Sheng Qinglin had even listed early on which young masters from prestigious families had bad character or bad personalities—he had basically gone through all the suitable matches².

At that time, there were indeed many people pursuing Sheng Linlang—young masters from prestigious families, talented young men, including no shortage of Alphas from noble households. But Sheng Linlang was rather fond of Xu Guangyao.

He was sincere and attentive to details, treating her well because he genuinely liked her.

Unlike those young masters from prestigious families who only wanted to pursue her to show off.

So Sheng Linlang said there was someone she was getting to know, but the relationship wasn't confirmed yet.

Sheng Qinglin immediately became anxious and said he wanted to return to China. Once Su Yao recovered, they would bring little Zhuzi back home.

Sheng Linlang teased him, saying there was no rush. After that, Sheng Qinglin would chat with her for ages, and the topic would often drift to his newborn daughter. His tone was full of pride and doting affection.

But no one expected that the next day, Sheng Qinglin got into a car accident on his way to propose to Su Yao. He didn't even make it to the hospital before he stopped breathing.

When the Sheng family found out, they immediately took a helicopter to rush there.

The Su Yao that Sheng Linlang saw then was withered and haggard, as if all the life had been drained from her. But with her just-one-month-old daughter in her arms, tears constantly streaming down her face, crying until her voice was hoarse and she couldn't control herself, she was still soothing her daughter, telling her not to cry.

The events of that day would always return as nightmares.

The Sheng parents, who had always been domineering, took Su Yao's daughter without any discussion and brought her back to China. Sheng Linlang promised Su Yao: "I will definitely bring your daughter back to you."

Because no one in the Sheng family could take care of a child.

Mother Sheng had been ill for years, and this time, because of what happened to Sheng Qinglin, she suddenly had a major breakdown. After returning from abroad, she was bedridden. Father Sheng hired a maternity nurse³ and nannies specifically to take care of the child. During the day, Sheng Linlang ran around everywhere; at night, she hid under her blanket and cried.

Sheng Linlang said: "I tried to persuade them, I begged them. I wanted Father to return you to Su Yao, but Father said no. Su Yao had gone mad, and a madwoman couldn't raise you properly."

"I later went to secretly see Su Yao. She indeed... wasn't in a good mental state." Sheng Linlang said: "I told Father I was willing to raise you together with Su Yao, but Father wouldn't allow it. He had always had extremely high expectations for Qinglin. Qinglin's death dealt him a huge blow, so he made me get married."

Sheng Linlang had always kept a low profile and rarely went out, so under her father's orders, she hastily got married. Before she could even enjoy newlywed life, she was already raising a child. At first, she truly felt extremely overwhelmed.

And Xu Qingzhu looked so much like Sheng Qinglin. At night, after Xu Qingzhu fell asleep, Sheng Linlang would watch her and cry.

When it came time to register the child's household registration and discuss the surname, Xu Guangyao naturally wanted her to take the surname Sheng. After all, she wasn't his own child, and he had no emotional attachment.

But Mother Sheng said firmly: "She'll take the surname Xu."

She told Xu Guangyao: "Raise her as your own child. Treat her well, and treat Linlang well too."

For a long time, Sheng Linlang didn't understand what her mother meant back then. After all, Xu Guangyao marrying her was considered marrying up⁴.

But later, after she became a mother herself, she understood. At that time, Mother Sheng wanted to protect both her daughter and her granddaughter. So she was willing to give up the "Sheng" surname, just wanting them to live better.

With the surname "Xu," she would be Xu Guangyao's daughter.

Sheng Linlang was never as brave as her younger brother. She didn't dare defy her parents, nor did she dare do too much.

The only thing she could do was raise her brother's child well. For this, she had even secretly had an abortion. It was only after Xu Qingzhu was a bit older that she had Xu Qingya.

Sheng Linlang said: "The person I've wronged most in my life is Su Yao."

She had once been so close to Su Yao, and had promised in front of her brother's body that she would return her daughter to her. But she couldn't keep that promise.

Later, after the Sheng parents passed away and Xu Qingzhu was a bit older, she also took Xu Qingzhu abroad.

Xu Qingzhu probably didn't remember, but at that time, Su Yao had already been sent to a psychiatric hospital for treatment. She had forgotten who Sheng Linlang was and didn't remember that she and Sheng Qinglin had even had a daughter.

Sheng Linlang was afraid of triggering her, so she brought Xu Qingzhu back.

For many years after that, they didn't contact each other again.

But guilt had always haunted Sheng Linlang, so she began to devote herself to Buddhism, trying to alleviate the pain that had built up inside her.

This was the first time Xu Qingzhu had heard anything about Sheng Qinglin—heard about his past, heard about his personality, heard about... his love for his daughter.

By the end, her eyes had turned red.

1. 上戶口 (shàng hù kǒu) - Registering a child in the household registration system (hukou) is an essential legal process in China. It determines the child's legal identity, citizenship, and access to public services. The surname given at registration becomes the child's legal surname. ⇐
2. 門當戶對 (mén dāng hù duì) - A traditional Chinese concept meaning "matching doors and windows," referring to marriages between families of equal social and economic standing. It was considered ideal for families to arrange marriages within similar social classes. ⇐
3. 月嫂 (yuè sǎo) - A specialized postpartum care provider in Chinese culture who helps new mothers and babies during the first month after birth. They assist with newborn care, breastfeeding, postpartum recovery meals, and other needs during this crucial period. ⇐
4. 高娶 (gāo qǔ) - "Marrying up" refers to marrying into a family of higher social or economic status. In this context, Xu Guangyao marrying into the prestigious Sheng family was considered advantageous for him. ⇐

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After finishing her story, Sheng Linlang had cried until she was a mess of tears. It had been so long since she had talked about these things with anyone. Once she started speaking about it, it felt like her heart was being wrenched with pain.

"How is Su Yao? Has she recovered her memory?" Sheng Linlang asked: "Now that you know, are you planning to acknowledge her?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "She still hasn't recovered her memory. Also, she had another daughter."

Sheng Linlang was stunned upon hearing this. After a long while, she managed a bitter smile. "That's good too. She's forgotten Qinglin, so she can live well from now on."

"It's still Uncle's daughter," Xu Qingzhu said. "Uncle had frozen his sperm abroad before."

"What?" Sheng Linlang was so astonished she couldn't speak.

Xu Qingzhu rested her head on her shoulder and asked softly: "Mom, do you think I should acknowledge her?"

Xu Qingzhu was also confused. For the first time, she realized that not everything was black and white, and no one was perfect.

In this whole matter, it seemed like no one was really at fault.

The only one who could be considered wrong was her domineering grandfather who had already passed away.

But her grandfather had also treated her very well.

The room was quiet for a long time. Sheng Linlang gently patted the back of her hand. "If she can remember, then acknowledge her."

"She loved you very much." Sheng Linlang said: "Even if you become her daughter, you're still my niece."

Xu Qingzhu fell into deep thought.

"Zhuzi." Sheng Linlang stroked the ends of her hair and said: "Everyone loves you very much and hopes you'll be well. The family business isn't important, the company isn't important—what matters most is that you live happily. When Su Yao gave birth to you back then, she had a difficult labor. She stayed in the delivery room for a day and a night, lost consciousness three times. Qinglin was there with her throughout. After you were born, he cried uncontrollably."

"That was the first time I ever saw him cry." Sheng Linlang said: "He told me then that if you ever treated Su Yao badly when you grew up, he would be the first one not to forgive you."

Xu Qingzhu's tears fell.

Sheng Linlang spoke as if coaxing a child: "So, acknowledge her."

Standing outside the door, Xu Guangyao held a glass of water and medicine in his hands. He slowly took a step back, his eyes red, then turned and went downstairs.